

Participant ID: 13MA45103

Lessons from Midway: Shaping a Thriving Future from the Past

27 April 2025

Word Count: 1456 words

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By the turn of the 21st century, the American flag has become a symbol of global security. Like many others of my generation, I am fortunate to have only ever known a world of freedom, peace, and prosperity. Yet, we must remember that these everyday rights were hard-won—earned through the blood, sweat, and tears of American soldiers in World War II. The Battle of Midway, a pivotal moment in the Pacific Theater, stands as a powerful reminder of that sacrifice. By looking to the past, we can learn valuable lessons to build a thriving future.

In the 1930s, a new imperial power arose in the East: The Empire of Japan. Determined to free Asia from European influence, Japan established the Greater East Asia Co-Prosperity Sphere [1]. Sensing Japan as a growing threat, the U.S. declared an oil embargo in 1941, cutting off 80% of Japan's oil supply [2]. However, instead of deterring Japan, this prompted the Japanese to seize more Allied territories for resources. Admiral Yamamoto, commander-in-chief of the Japanese Combined Fleet, believed that in order to continue its expansion, Japan had to neutralize the U.S. Thus, in December 1941, Japanese aircraft attacked the U.S. Pacific Fleet at Pearl Harbor, Hawaii [2]. The next day, the United States declared war on Japan. As Yamamoto remarked, "I fear all we have done is to awaken a sleeping giant and fill him with a terrible resolve."

1942 was a year with heightened tensions across the Pacific Theater. In May, Japanese and U.S. fleets clashed for the first time at the Battle of Coral Sea. From the beginning, it was clear that the Japanese fleet outmatched the American fleet in terms of both quality and quantity. Nonetheless, it was the strategic thinking, decision-making, and resilience of Americans at the Battle of Midway that claimed the ultimate victory.

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Strategy was key in the Battle of Midway. Located halfway between Japan and Hawaii, Midway Atoll held strategic value as a U.S. naval base. Yamamoto believed claiming the island would give the Japanese an upper hand in continuing its conquest of the Pacific and entice American carriers into battle. His plan was to finish what Pearl Harbor started by destroying the remaining U.S. fleet in a surprise ambush. But, unbeknownst to the Japanese, U.S. Naval Intelligence at Pearl Harbor had already discovered their plan.

American cryptanalysts had decoded the Japanese naval code JN25. Through translating radio interceptions, they hypothesized that a planned attack on a location nicknamed “AF” could be referring to Midway. To confirm this, they ingeniously fooled the Japanese by sending out an unencrypted message from Midway stating that the island was “running out of fresh water”. Soon after, the Japanese reported that “AF” was running out of water, confirming to U.S. intelligence that “AF” indeed meant Midway [3]. These findings gave Americans a tremendous advantage in preparation. By doing this, the U.S. had already won half the battle.

The Battle of Midway also shows how flexibility in decision-making can determine the outcome of a conflict. As Sun Tzu said, “Military tactics are like water.” This means that military decisions must flow and adapt according to changing surroundings. A good general must be prepared for any unexpected situation. Early in the morning of June 3, 1942, the Japanese fleet was approaching Midway when Admiral Yamamoto was notified of unanticipated American carriers in the area. Even so, Yamamoto maintained radio silence and refrained from informing Admiral Nagumo, who oversaw the main carrier battle group [4]. Because of this poor communication, Nagumo would go on to follow the original plan despite the completely changed circumstances.

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On June 4, 108 Japanese planes launched a successful first strike on Midway [3], but a second strike was needed to finish off the island's defenses [4]. At 7:15 am, Nagumo ordered all his planes to rearm from torpedoes to land bombs in preparation. However, just ten minutes later, a scout reported sighting ten American ships. In this moment, Nagumo had to choose to continue the second strike on Midway or confront the American ships. At 7:45 am, Nagumo ordered all planes still armed with torpedoes to prepare for attacking the American fleet. This decision allowed time for refueling returning planes and launching a coordinated attack—but it also delayed action, leaving the Japanese carriers vulnerable. In this situation, Nagumo could have retreated his fleet to buy more time for reequipping his planes. But, the cultural value of honor may have hindered Nagumo from making the safest, most rational choice. Furthermore, obliging to follow Yamamoto's original plan prevented Nagumo from being a flexible leader.

While inflexibility troubled Japanese leadership, American commanders were willing to adapt to unfolding realities. Mid-morning on June 4, Commander McClusky and his air group arrived at the predicted location of the Japanese fleet only to find that the Japanese had already changed course. Instead of returning to the *USS Enterprise*, McClusky decided to continue northwest, where his group finally located the Japanese destroyer *Arashi*. This decision demonstrates the courage and determination of American soldiers. If McClusky hadn't been flexible enough to alter his plans, perhaps the U.S. may have never located the Japanese fleet. It was one commander's valiant intuition that brought forth the most consequential hour at the Battle of Midway. At 10:22 am, McClusky's Dauntlesses crippled both the carriers *Kaga* and *Akagi*, while 17 more dive-bombers from the *USS Yorktown* struck the *Soryu*. Within five minutes, three out of the four Japanese carriers were up in flames [5]. The key decisions made by

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Admirals Yamamoto, Nagumo, and McClusky exemplify how flexibility and communication in leadership can greatly impact any situation.

The Japanese possessed an advantage in terms of technology, but the Americans were unbeatable in their resilience. At noon on June 4, dive-bombers from the only remaining Japanese carrier, *Hiryu*, badly damaged the *USS Yorktown*'s flight deck. At 2:30 pm, *Hiryu*'s torpedo planes struck the *Yorktown*'s port side, causing it to tilt. At 5:00 pm, Captain Buckmaster ordered all servicemen to "abandon ship" [4]. A veteran from the *USS Yorktown* remembered, "I got sick and swam away from the ship for three or four hours" [6]. Photographer Bill Roy described it as "the most difficult thing...you're in the water and you can't breathe...you're throwing up or getting sick... it burns your eyes, burns your nose... you're gulping seawater and fuel oil" [7].

On June 6, 149 brave men along with 26 officers volunteered as a salvage team to save the beloved *USS Yorktown*. Destroyer *USS Hammann* accompanied the wounded carrier, offering dewatering pumps and keeping watch for Japanese attacks. But hope became heartbreak at 1:35 pm, when the *USS Hammann* was fatally struck by a Japanese submarine. Just two hours later, two more torpedoes tore into the *Yorktown*'s underside. On June 7, 1942, *USS Yorktown* sank, bringing along with it 141 honorable servicemen. [5]. Nevertheless, the *Yorktown* left behind a legacy of hope, courage, and unwavering determination. Incredible resilience was shown by both the crew of the *Yorktown* as they helped one another and braved the dangerous seawaters. Remaining hopeful in the hardest moments was what allowed the soldiers to persevere to safety. The final victory at Midway was earned by the American soldiers who fought until the very end.

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During the Battle of Midway, U.S. intelligence was vigilant and proactive, often outthinking the Japanese. Moreover, both sides faced difficult decisions, but it was the American leadership's flexibility under pressure that tipped the scale. Finally, American soldiers never gave up in the face of a more advanced opposition. To this day, thousands of soldiers remain at the bottom of the Pacific Ocean, eternally defending Midway. Their sacrifice turned the tide of the Pacific Theater, halting momentum in Japanese expansion in favor of the Allies. After a humiliating loss, the pride of Japanese generals was turned into alarm and caution. Conversely, the U.S. would go on to triumph in a series of battles in its island-hopping campaign.

More than eight decades later, the Battle of Midway still teaches the importance of strategy, flexibility, and resilience. Without these three qualities, the Allies may have never secured victory and the age of equality, freedom, and peace that followed. As we face our own battles today—whether personal, societal, or global—we must remember Midway. Success begins with a well-crafted strategy, yet the future is unpredictable. It calls for the agility to adapt, the strength to persist, and the vision to lead. Our world now rests in the hands of a new generation. And like those who came before, it is our duty to rise, to lead with wisdom, and to shape a future defined not by conflict, but by justice, liberty, and harmony.

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